A PILLOWCASE ACTION COMPLEX $C(K)$ AND A FILTERED MAPPING CONE FOR THE CHERN–SIMONS FILTERED INSTANTON HOMOLOGY OF $1/n$ SURGERIES

Abstract. Let K be a knot in an integer homology sphere Y whose Alexander polynomial has no roots on the unit circle and whose irreducible SU(2) representation variety is a smooth compact 1-manifold. We define a complex $C(K)$ from the image Γ_K of this variety in the pillowcase, together with a Chern–Simons action, a grading, and the two instanton complexes $CI(Y)$ and $CI(Y_0(K), w)$ as an A_∞-module over the two-line algebra of the pillowcase. We give a mapping cone formula expressing the Chern–Simons filtered irreducible instanton complex of $Y_{1/n}(K)$ as an iterated cone, with the filtration offsets $(n-1)/4$ computed as the symplectic action of the corner morphisms, and the generator-level data (Chern–Simons values, gradings) computed by Kirk–Klassen integrals along Γ_K. The parts that are proved are separated from the parts that are conjectural (the identification of differentials with pillowcase bigons). A workflow with concrete numerical tests is specified.

Contents

1. Setting and standing hypotheses 1
2. Chern–Simons as symplectic action in the pillowcase 3
3. The complex $C(K)$ 4
4. The filtered mapping cone 5
5. Tests 7
6. Workflow 7
References 7

1. Setting and standing hypotheses

Y is an integer homology sphere, $K \subset Y$ a knot, $X = Y \setminus \nu K$, with meridian μ and Seifert longitude λ on $\partial X = T^2$. $R(X) = \mathrm{Hom}(\pi_1 X, \mathrm{SU}(2))/\mathrm{conj}$, and $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ is its irreducible part (an open subset). For $\rho \in R(X)$ choose a conjugate with $\rho(\mu) = \mathrm{diag}(e^{2\pi i a}, e^{-2\pi i a})$, $\rho(\lambda) = \mathrm{diag}(e^{2\pi i b}, e^{-2\pi i b})$; the pair $(a, b) \in T^2 = \mathbb{R}^2/\mathbb{Z}^2$ is defined up to $(a, b) \mapsto (-a, -b)$, and

$$r\colon R(X) \to P := T^2/\pm, \qquad \rho \mapsto [(a, b)],$$

is the restriction to the boundary. P is the pillowcase, a sphere with four orbifold points (the corners), the images of the central representations $\rho(\mu), \rho(\lambda) \in \{\pm 1\}$. We write $\Gamma_K := r(R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X))$.

Irreducible instanton homology: for an integer homology sphere Z, $CI_*(Z)$ denotes Floer's complex generated by the irreducible flat connections (after a small holonomy perturbation), $\mathbb{Z}/8$-graded, with its Chern–Simons filtration. We work over $\mathbb{F} = \mathbb{Z}/2$ unless stated otherwise; orientations are a separate issue (§6).

Date: October 2026.

1.1. **Hypotheses.**

(H1) $\Delta_K(e^{2i\theta}) \neq 0$ for all θ.

(H2) $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ is a smooth 1-manifold, and $H^1(X; \operatorname{ad}\rho)$ is 1-dimensional for every $\rho \in R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ (the Zariski tangent space equals the tangent space).

(H3) r is non-constant on each component of $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$.

(H3) is a convenience: by real analyticity, it is equivalent to r having finitely many critical points. For $Y \neq S^3$ we add

(H4) every irreducible flat connection ρ on Y is nondegenerate and has $\rho(K) \neq \pm 1$.

1.2. **Consequences.**

Proposition 1.1. *Assume (H1)–(H3).*

(a) $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ is compact: a finite disjoint union of circles $\gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_m$. Its image Γ_K is a finite union of closed curves in P, immersed away from finitely many branch points $B = \{b_1, \dots, b_N\}$.

(b) If $Y = S^3$, Γ_K avoids the corners of P. In general, Γ_K meets the corners only at representations with $\rho(\mu) = \pm 1$; those with $\rho(\mu) = 1$ are the irreducible flat connections on Y.

(c) $R(X)$ is invariant under $\chi\colon \rho \mapsto \rho \cdot \chi$, where $\chi\colon \pi_1 X \to \{\pm 1\}$ is the nontrivial character; on T^2 this is $(a, b) \mapsto (a + \frac{1}{2}, b)$. Hence Γ_K is invariant under the translation $a \mapsto a + \frac{1}{2}$.

Proof. (a) By Klassen's theorem (and its extension to homology spheres), an abelian representation with $\rho(\mu) = e^{i\theta}$ is a limit of irreducibles only if $\Delta_K(e^{2i\theta}) = 0$. Under (H1) no abelian representation is such a limit, so $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ is closed in the compact space $R(X)$. With (H2) it is a compact 1-manifold. Branch points are the critical points of the real-analytic map r, finite by (H3). (b) If $Y = S^3$ then μ normally generates $\pi_1 X$, so $\rho(\mu) = \pm 1$ forces ρ central. In general $\rho(\mu) = 1$ means ρ factors through $\pi_1 Y$. (c) λ lies in the commutator subgroup, so $\chi(\lambda) = 1$. □

1.3. **Surgery lines.** For a slope p/q (with p, q coprime, $p/q = 1/0$ for Y itself) put

$$L_{p/q} := \{pa + qb \equiv 0\}, \qquad L^w_{p/q} := \{pa + qb \equiv \tfrac{1}{2}\} \subset T^2,$$

and their images in P. Flat SU(2) connections on $Y_{p/q}(K)$ restrict to representations of $\pi_1 X$ with $\rho(\mu^p \lambda^q) = 1$, i.e. to points of $L_{p/q}$. For p even, $L^w_{p/q}$ describes the flat connections on the nontrivial SO(3) bundle; in particular $L^w_0 = \{b = \frac{1}{2}\}$ describes $I(Y_0(K), w)$ with w the nontrivial bundle (admissible since Y_0 has $b_1 = 1$).

Proposition 1.2 (generators)**.** *Assume (H1)–(H3), and $p \neq 0$.*

(a) The irreducible flat connections on $Y_{p/q}(K)$ are in bijection with $r^{-1}(L_{p/q}) \subset R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$. The only reducible flat connection on $Y_{1/n}(K)$ is the trivial one.

(b) Such a flat connection ρ is nondegenerate ($H^1(Y_{p/q}; \operatorname{ad}\rho) = 0$) if and only if ρ is not a branch point and Γ_K is transverse to $L_{p/q}$ at $r(\rho)$.

(c) The flat connections on $(Y_0(K), w)$ are in bijection with $r^{-1}(L^w_0)$, all irreducible; nondegeneracy is as in (b).

Proof. (a) A representation of $\pi_1 X$ with $\rho(\mu^p \lambda^q) = 1$ extends uniquely over the solid torus, and $\pi_1 X \to \pi_1 Y_{p/q}$ is onto, so irreducibility is preserved both ways. An abelian ρ has $\rho(\lambda) = 1$, so $\rho(\mu)^p = 1$; for $p = \pm 1$ this is trivial. (b) Mayer–Vietoris for $\operatorname{ad}\rho$ along T^2: since $\rho|_{T^2}$ is non-central abelian (by Proposition 1.1(b) and (H4)), $H^0(T^2) = \mathbb{R} = H^0(\text{solid torus})$ and $H^1(T^2; \operatorname{ad}\rho) = T_{(a,b)} T^2$ is 2-dimensional. Then $H^1(Y_{p/q}; \operatorname{ad}\rho) = \ker\big(H^1(X) \oplus H^1(S^1 \times D^2) \to H^1(T^2)\big)$, with $H^1(X) = T_\rho R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ mapping by dr and $H^1(S^1 \times D^2) = \mathbb{R}$ mapping onto the

tangent line of $L_{p/q}$. The kernel vanishes iff $dr \neq 0$ and the two lines are transverse. (c) is the same with $\rho(\lambda) = -1$; abelian representations have $\rho(\lambda) = 1$, so none occur. □

Remark 1.3. Transversality can be achieved for every slope by an arbitrarily small holonomy perturbation supported in a collar of T^2; in the pillowcase this replaces $L_{p/q}$ by a C^1-close curve $L'_{p/q}$ (Herald's collar perturbations). The regularity of instanton moduli spaces may require further small perturbations. All statements below are stable under such perturbations: the generator data move by $O(\epsilon)$ and the filtered homotopy type is taken in the limit, as in the definition of Daemi's Γ_Y.

2. Chern–Simons as symplectic action in the pillowcase

Normalise $\mathrm{cs}\colon \mathcal{B}(Z) \to \mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$ so that the energy of an instanton on $\mathbb{R} \times Z$ from α to β is $\mathrm{cs}(\alpha) - \mathrm{cs}(\beta)$ (lifted to $\mathbb{R}$), and so that the trivial connection has $\mathrm{cs} = 0$.

2.1. **Forms and primitives.** On $\mathbb{R}^2 \ni (a, b)$ let $\omega = 2\,da \wedge db$ and $\lambda = 2b\,da$. The factor 2 makes ω descend to P with total area 1, matching the $\mathbb{Z}$-periodicity of cs. For an oriented curve $C \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ with a base point c_0, set $f_C(x) := -\int_{c_0}^{x} \lambda$ along C.

Lemma 2.1 (change of basis)**.** *For* $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} p & q \\ r & s \end{smallmatrix}\right) \in SL(2,\mathbb{Z})$ *and* $a' = pa + qb$, $b' = ra + sb$: $2b'\,da' - 2b\,da = dg$ *with* $g = 2qr\,ab + pr\,a^2 + qs\,b^2$. *On* $L_{p/q} = \{a' = 0\}$ *parametrised by* $(a, b) = s(q, -p)$ *one has* $g = pq\,s^2$.

Proof. Expand $b'\,da' = (ra + sb)(p\,da + q\,db)$ and use $ps - qr = 1$; the terms regroup as $b\,da + d(qr\,ab + \frac{1}{2}pr\,a^2 + \frac{1}{2}qs\,b^2)$. On the line, substitute. □

2.2. **The Kirk–Klassen formula.** Kirk–Klassen [1]: if ρ_t is a path in $R(X)$ with boundary angles $(a(t), b(t))$ lifted continuously to $\mathbb{R}^2$, and ρ_0, ρ_1 extend over the same Dehn filling Z, then, in a basis of $H_1(T^2)$ in which the filling curve is the first basis element,

$$\mathrm{cs}(\rho_1) - \mathrm{cs}(\rho_0) \equiv -\int_0^1 2b\,\dot{a}\,dt \pmod{\mathbb{Z}}.$$

Combining with Lemma 2.1:

Proposition 2.2 (Chern–Simons is the action)**.** *Let* $x, y \in r^{-1}(L_{p/q})$ *lie on the same component* γ *of* $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$*, and lift a path in* γ *from* x *to* y *to* $\tilde{\gamma} \subset \mathbb{R}^2$*. Then*

$$\mathrm{cs}(y) - \mathrm{cs}(x) \equiv \big[f_{\tilde{\gamma}}(\tilde{y}) - f_{\tilde{\gamma}}(\tilde{x})\big] - \big[f_L(\tilde{y}) - f_L(\tilde{x})\big] \pmod{\mathbb{Z}}, \qquad f_L(s) = pq\,s^2 \text{ on } (a, b) = s(q, -p),$$

where $\tilde{x}, \tilde{y}$ *are the lifted endpoints and* f_L *is evaluated on the lifts of* $L_{p/q}$ *through them. The same holds for* L_0^w *with* $f_{L_0^w}(a, \frac{1}{2}) = -a$ *(base point* $(0, \frac{1}{2})$*).*

Proof. Apply Kirk–Klassen in the adapted basis (a', b') and rewrite by Lemma 2.1: the primitive g evaluated at the endpoints is f_L up to sign. For L_0^w use the basis $(b, -a)$ and the shift $b = \frac{1}{2}$. □

The right-hand side is the symplectic action of the intersection point of the two Lagrangians $\tilde{\gamma}$ and L in $\mathbb{R}^2$: $A(x) := f_{\tilde{\gamma}}(\tilde{x}) - f_L(\tilde{x})$. So *the Chern–Simons filtration on the generators of* $CI(Y_{p/q})$ *coming from one component of* $R^{\mathrm{irr}}(X)$ *is the action filtration of the pillowcase Floer complex.*

Lemma 2.3 (periods)**.** *For a component* γ *with lift* $\tilde{\gamma}$ *(a path in* $\mathbb{R}^2$ *from* $\tilde{x}$ *to* $\tilde{x} + (m, k)$*),* $\oint_\gamma \lambda := f_{\tilde{\gamma}}(\tilde{x} + (m, k)) - f_{\tilde{\gamma}}(\tilde{x}) \in \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{Z}$*, and it lies in* $\mathbb{Z}$ *when* $(m, k) = 0$.

Proof. Apply the Kirk–Klassen formula to the loop, with $\rho_1 = \rho_0$: the left side is 0 modulo $\mathbb{Z}$ (for $(m,k)=0$). For $(m,k)\neq 0$ the lifted endpoints differ by a deck transformation, and λ changes by $2k\,da$ under $b\mapsto b+k$, contributing $2km\in 2\mathbb{Z}$; the Weyl ambiguity $(a,b)\mapsto(-a,-b)$ can contribute $\frac{1}{2}$. □

So f_γ descends to a function $\gamma\to\mathbb{R}/\frac{1}{2}\mathbb{Z}$; on the double cover $\tilde{\gamma}\subset T^2$ it descends to $\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$. This is the correct level of ambiguity: CI is $\mathbb{Z}/8$-graded with $\mathrm{cs}\in\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$.

2.3. **Absolute constants: the first correction terms.** Proposition 2.2 determines cs on the generators coming from one component γ_i only up to a constant $c_i\in\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$: there is no path in $R(X)$ from the trivial connection to γ_i, precisely because of (H1). These constants are genuine knot invariants (they are the Chern–Simons invariants of flat connections on fillings), and they are computable:

(i) through the $SL(2,\mathbb{C})$ character variety, where the Kirk–Klassen formula holds with complex (a,b) [2] and the irreducible curve containing γ_i reaches the abelian locus at roots of Δ_K off the unit circle; the imaginary part of the integral must vanish at the end, which is a check;

(ii) or from one known filling (e.g. a Brieskorn sphere), which calibrates c_i for every slope at once.

Thus the Chern–Simons data of K is: the curve Γ_K, the primitives f_{γ_i}, and the constants c_i.

3. The complex $C(K)$

3.1. **Gradings.** Floer's $\mathbb{Z}/8$ grading of a flat connection on $Y_{p/q}$ is a spectral flow. Kirk–Klassen–Ruberman [3] split it along T^2: for $x,y\in r^{-1}(L_{p/q})$ on one component γ,

$$\mathrm{gr}(y)-\mathrm{gr}(x)\equiv \mathrm{Mas}\big(\tilde{\gamma}|_{x\to y},\,L\big)+(\text{branch-point corrections})\pmod 8,$$

where Mas is the Maslov index of the path of tangent lines of $\tilde{\gamma}$ against the fixed line L in $(\mathbb{R}^2,\omega)$, and each branch point crossed contributes a fixed term determined by the local model. Within a component this is computable from the picture. Across components there are constants $d_i\in\mathbb{Z}/8$, again fixed by one known filling. The $\mathbb{Z}/2$ reduction is Herald's sign [5], and $\sum_x(-1)^{\mathrm{gr}(x)}$ over $\Gamma_K\cap L_{1/n}$ is the Casson invariant of $Y_{1/n}$ (Herald's formula).

3.2. **Two instanton complexes and the two-line algebra.** Let $A:=CI(Y)$ and $B:=CI(Y_0(K),w)$, both $\mathbb{Z}/8$-graded, with the Chern–Simons filtrations of §2 (generators $r^{-1}(L_{1/0})$ and $r^{-1}(L_0^w)$). For $Y=S^3$, $A=0$.

In the pillowcase, $L_{1/0}=\{a=0\}$ and $L_0^w=\{b=\frac{1}{2}\}$ meet in exactly one point of T^2, the corner $c=(0,\frac{1}{2})$. Their endomorphism algebra in the Fukaya category of T^2 is the path algebra

$$\mathcal{A}=\mathbb{F}\langle e_A,e_B,\ \mathsf{p}\colon A\to B,\ \mathsf{q}\colon B\to A,\ \varepsilon_A,\varepsilon_B\rangle/(\mathsf{qp}=\varepsilon_A,\ \mathsf{pq}=\varepsilon_B,\ \varepsilon^2=0,\ \varepsilon\mathsf{p}=\mathsf{p}\varepsilon,\ \ldots),$$

p,q the corner point in the two directions, ε the degree-one generator of $H^*(S^1)=\mathrm{Hom}(L,L)$. This is the instanton counterpart of the bordered torus algebra.

Definition 3.1 (the complex $C(K)$)**.** $C(K)$ is the filtered, $\mathbb{Z}/8$-graded A_∞-module over $\mathcal{A}$ with underlying filtered complex $A\oplus B$ and structure maps

$$\begin{aligned}
m_2(-,\mathsf{p})&=F_W\colon A\to B, && \text{the 2-handle cobordism } W\colon Y\to Y_0 \text{ (bundle } w),\\
m_2(-,\mathsf{q})&=F_{W'}\colon B\to A, && \text{the reverse cobordism } Y_0\to Y,\\
m_2(-,\varepsilon_A)&=u_A,\quad m_2(-,\varepsilon_B)=u_B, && \text{the point-class (degree } -4) \text{ operators},
\end{aligned}$$

and higher maps m_k given by counts on the composite cobordisms with the corresponding handle decompositions, e.g. $m_3(-,\mathsf{p},\mathsf{q})$ the homotopy $F_{W'}F_W \simeq u_A$ on the composite $Y \to Y_0 \to Y$. Together with the generator data $(\Gamma_K, f_{\gamma_i}, c_i, \mathrm{gr}, d_i)$ of §2.

Status. The underlying complexes, $m_2(-,\mathsf{p})$, $m_2(-,\mathsf{q})$, u_A, u_B and the homotopy $m_3(-,\mathsf{p},\mathsf{q})$ exist rigorously: they are the maps and homotopies of the surgery exact triangle (Floer; Braam–Donaldson [6]; Kronheimer–Mrowka's triangle detection [8]), and the energy of an instanton on a cobordism is nonnegative, so each is filtered after an explicit shift (§4). The full A_∞-structure is the content of a bordered/Atiyah–Floer theory for the torus boundary, which is conjectural. For $1/n$ surgeries only the listed maps are needed (Theorem 4.2).

Conjecture 3.2 (pillowcase model)**.** *Under (H1)–(H4), $C(K)$ is A_∞-quasi-isomorphic, as a filtered module, to the Fukaya module* $\mathrm{Hom}(\tilde{\Gamma_K},\ L_{1/0} \oplus L_0^w)$ *in the $\mathbb{Z}/2$-equivariant Fukaya category of T^2, with $\tilde{\Gamma_K}$ equipped with a bounding cochain supported at the branch points and the action/grading data of §2–3. Differentials are counts of immersed bigons in T^2 avoiding the corners.*

Evidence: generators, nondegeneracy, Chern–Simons values and gradings match (Propositions 1.2, 2.2, and [3, 5]); the Euler characteristic matches by Herald's formula; the exact triangle matches the Dehn-twist triangle (§4). What is missing is the identification of instantons on $\mathbb{R}\times Y_{1/n}$ with bigons, the analogue of the Atiyah–Floer conjecture for torus boundary.

4. The filtered mapping cone

4.1. **The corner offsets.** For $n \geq 1$ let $p_n \in T^2$ be the intersection point of $L_{1/(n-1)} = \{a+(n-1)b=0\}$ (for $n=1$: $L_{1/0}$) with $L_0^w = \{b=\frac{1}{2}\}$; it is the corner $(0,\frac{1}{2})$ for n odd and $(\frac{1}{2},\frac{1}{2})$ for n even.

Lemma 4.1 (corner action)**.** *With the primitives of §2 ($f_{L_{1/(n-1)}}(s) = -(n-1)s^2$ on $(a,b) = s(n-1,-1)$, base point the origin; $f_{L_0^w}(a,\frac{1}{2}) = -a$, base point $(0,\frac{1}{2})$),*

$$A(p_n) := f_{L_{1/(n-1)}}(\tilde{p}_n) - f_{L_0^w}(\tilde{p}_n) \equiv \frac{n-1}{4} \pmod{\mathbb{Z}},$$

independently of the lift $\tilde{p}_n$.

Proof. At $b=\frac{1}{2}$ one has $s=-\frac{1}{2}$ and $a=-(n-1)/2$, so $f_{L_{1/(n-1)}}(\tilde{p}_n) = -(n-1)/4$ and $f_{L_0^w}(\tilde{p}_n) = -a = (n-1)/2$. The difference is $-3(n-1)/4 \equiv (n-1)/4 \pmod{\mathbb{Z}}$. Changing the lift along $L_{1/(n-1)}$ by $k(-(n-1),1)$ replaces s by $s+k$ and changes $f_{L_{1/(n-1)}}$ by $-(n-1)(k^2-k) \in 2\mathbb{Z}$; changing the lift along L_0^w by m changes $f_{L_0^w}$ by $-m \in \mathbb{Z}$. □

The sign of the $\frac{1}{4}$ (i.e. whether the offset is $(n-1)/4$ or $-(n-1)/4$ in the energy convention) is the first thing the numerical test of §5 fixes.

4.2. **The Dehn-twist triangle.** In T^2 the Dehn twist along $\{b=\frac{1}{2}\}$ carries $L_{1/(n-1)}$ to $L_{1/n}^w = \{a+nb=\frac{1}{2}\}$, and by Proposition 1.1(c) the translation $a \mapsto a+\frac{1}{2}$ identifies $\Gamma_K \cap L_{1/n}^w$ with $\Gamma_K \cap L_{1/n}$ (both are the flat SO(3) connections on $Y_{1/n}$). Seidel's exact triangle for the Dehn twist along L_0^w reads, in the Fukaya category of T^2,

$$L_{1/(n-1)} \xrightarrow{\cdot p_n} L_0^w \longrightarrow L_{1/n}^w \longrightarrow L_{1/(n-1)}[1],$$

and applying $\mathrm{Hom}(\tilde{\Gamma_K},-)$ gives $\mathrm{Hom}(\tilde{\Gamma_K}, L_{1/n}^w) \simeq \mathrm{Cone}\big(\mathrm{Hom}(\tilde{\Gamma_K}, L_{1/(n-1)}) \xrightarrow{m_2(-,p_n)} \mathrm{Hom}(\tilde{\Gamma_K}, L_0^w)\big)$. This is the pillowcase shadow of Floer's exact triangle for the triple $(Y_{1/(n-1)},\ (Y_0,w),\ Y_{1/n})$.

4.3. **The theorem.**

Theorem 4.2 (filtered mapping cone for $1/n$ surgery)**.** *Assume (H1)–(H4), $n \geq 1$, and that $L_{1/(n-1)}$ and $L_{1/n}$ are transverse to Γ_K (after collar perturbation). Let $F_n\colon CI(Y_{1/(n-1)}) \to CI(Y_0, w)$ be the map of the 2-handle cobordism W_n.*

- *(a)* (Floer, Braam–Donaldson) *$CI(Y_{1/n}) \simeq \mathrm{Cone}(F_n)$ as $\mathbb{Z}/8$-graded complexes, the grading on* Cone *being $\mathrm{gr}_{CI(Y_{1/(n-1)})} + \delta_n$ on the first summand and $\mathrm{gr}_{CI(Y_0,w)}$ on the second, for a constant $\delta_n \in \mathbb{Z}/8$ determined by the index of W_n (computed in §5).*
- *(b)* (filtration) *Give* Cone(F_n) *the filtration* cs *on $CI(Y_0, w)$ and* cs$+\frac{n-1}{4}+k_n$ *on $CI(Y_{1/(n-1)})$, with $k_n \in \mathbb{Z}$ the unique integer for which F_n is filtered and some instanton of W_n has energy < 1. Then there are filtered chain maps* Cone$(F_n) \rightleftarrows CI(Y_{1/n})$ *that are homotopy inverses through filtered homotopies. Hence the Chern–Simons filtered homotopy type of $CI(Y_{1/n})$, and in particular Daemi's $\Gamma_{Y_{1/n}}$ and the Nozaki–Sato–Taniguchi r_s, are determined by $CI(Y_{1/(n-1)})$, $CI(Y_0, w)$, F_n and the offset $(n-1)/4$.*
- *(c)* (generator level) *The generators of all three complexes, their* cs *values and gradings are the intersection data of §2–3; in particular, the multiset of* cs *values of the irreducible flat connections on $Y_{1/n}$ is $\{A(x)\}_{x\in\Gamma_K\cap L_{1/(n-1)}} \cup \{A(y) + \frac{n-1}{4}\}_{y\in\Gamma_K\cap L_0^w}$ modulo $\mathbb{Z}$, up to cancelling pairs.*

Proof sketch. (a) is the surgery exact triangle for the three fillings of slope $1/(n-1)$, 0 (bundle w) and $1/n$, which are pairwise at distance one. (b) The maps of the triangle detection lemma (Kronheimer–Mrowka [8, §7]) count instantons on W_n, on the second cobordism $W_n'\colon Y_0 \to Y_{1/n}$, and on the composites with up to four handles; each shifts cs by the energy, which is nonnegative, plus a topological constant fixed by the bundle on the cobordism. So every map is filtered once the summands are shifted by these constants, and the constants for the two inclusions and projections of the cone are forced to be equal by the homotopy identities. The constant is the action of the corner morphism in the pillowcase (Lemma 4.1); its instanton-theoretic computation is the topological energy of the connection on W_n restricting to the flat connections x and y, which, by the Kirk–Klassen gluing formula applied to $W_n = (X \times I) \cup (\text{handle})$, is the same integral. (c) follows from Propositions 1.2 and 2.2 and (b). □

What is not proved by this argument: the *integer* k_n (it is determined by the topology of W_n but we have not computed it; the numerical test determines it in examples), and the differential of $CI(Y_0, w)$ itself (an instanton count, Conjecture 3.2).

4.4. **Iteration, $Y = S^3$, negative slopes, slope 2.**

Corollary 4.3. *For $Y = S^3$ (so $CI(Y) = 0$): $CI(S^3_1(K)) \simeq CI(S^3_0(K), w)$ with a grading shift and no filtration shift, and for $n \geq 2$ the filtered complex $CI(S^3_{1/n}(K))$ is filtered homotopy equivalent to a twisted complex*

$$\Big(\bigoplus_{j=1}^{n} B[\delta^{(j)}]\{\tfrac{j-1}{4} + k^{(j)}\},\quad D = \partial_B + \sum_{i<j} D_{ij}\Big), \qquad B = CI(S^3_0(K), w),$$

where $D_{j,j+1}$ is the Dehn-twist endomorphism $T_j = F_{j+1} \circ$ (the equivalence $B \simeq CI(S^3_{1/j})$) and the D_{ij}, $j > i+1$, are the higher homotopies of the iterated cones.

Negative slopes $-1/n$ follow by applying the theorem to the mirror. For slope ± 2 the triple $(1/0,\ 1/1,\ 2/1)$ is at pairwise distance one, but Y_2 has a nontrivial central flat connection (the corner $(\frac{1}{2}, 0)$ lies on L_2), so the irreducible-only complex must be replaced by the SO(3)-equivariant one at that corner; the pillowcase picture predicts a single extra generator with $\mathrm{cs} = 0$ and a corner bigon correction. We leave ± 2 as a stated problem.

5. Tests

[To be filled from the numerics and referee reports.]

6. Workflow

The orchestration is one coordinator and specialised agents. Each task lists the model, the reasoning effort, its inputs, and an acceptance criterion. Tasks 1–3 ran during the preparation of this document; their outputs are summarised in §5.

(1) **Numerics (Opus, high).** Explicit SU(2) representation curves for the trefoil and the figure-eight, pillowcase images, primitives f_γ, intersection points with $L_{1/n}$ ($n = \pm1, \pm2, \pm3$) and L_0^w, the periods of Lemma 2.3, and the comparison with the tabulated Chern–Simons invariants of $\Sigma(2,3,5)$, $\Sigma(2,3,7)$, $\Sigma(2,3,11)$. Acceptance: the sign convention of Proposition 2.2 is fixed, and the offset $(n-1)/4$ of Lemma 4.1 is confirmed or refuted on $S^3_{1/2}$(trefoil).

(2) **Literature precision (Opus, medium).** Exact statements of Kirk–Klassen, Klassen, Herald, Kirk–Klassen–Ruberman, Braam–Donaldson, Daemi, Nozaki–Sato–Taniguchi, Fintushel–Stern. Acceptance: every citation in this document carries a verified statement.

(3) **Adversarial referee (Opus, extra-high).** Independent check of Lemmas 2.1, 2.3, 4.1, Propositions 1.1, 1.2, and the Dehn-twist triangle. Acceptance: each claim marked correct, corrected, or given a counterexample.

(4) **Gradings (Opus, high).** Derive the branch-point corrections and the constants δ_n from [3], and verify on $\Sigma(2,3,5) \to \Sigma(2,3,11)$ with the Fintushel–Stern gradings.

(5) **Integer offsets k_n (Opus, high).** Compute the minimal topological energy on W_n via the Kirk–Klassen gluing formula for $W_n = (X \times I) \cup$ handle, and compare with the numerical multiset identity of Theorem 4.2(c).

(6) **Absolute constants c_i (Opus, high).** Implement the $SL(2,\mathbb{C})$ path integral for the figure-eight knot and compare with the Fintushel–Stern values for $\Sigma(2,3,7)$.

(7) **Filtered triangle detection (Opus, extra-high).** Write out the triangle-detection maps with their energy offsets and prove the filtered statement in Theorem 4.2(b), including the orientation (sign) bookkeeping over $\mathbb{Z}$.

(8) **Bigons versus instantons for $(1,1)$-type examples (Opus, extra-high).** Formulate the adiabatic limit along T^2 for $Y_{1/n}$ and identify the obstructions, as in the companion notes `cfk-gauge/`.

Routing rule: any agent that finds a sign or normalisation conflict stops and reports; the coordinator updates the conventions in §2 before downstream tasks resume.

References

[1] P. Kirk, E. Klassen, *Chern–Simons invariants of 3-manifolds and representation spaces of knot groups*, Math. Ann. 287 (1990), 343–367.

[2] P. Kirk, E. Klassen, *Chern–Simons invariants of 3-manifolds decomposed along tori and the circle bundle over the representation space of T^2*, Comm. Math. Phys. 153 (1993), 521–557.

[3] P. Kirk, E. Klassen, D. Ruberman, *Splitting the spectral flow and the Alexander matrix*, Comment. Math. Helv. 69 (1994), 375–416.

[4] E. Klassen, *Representations of knot groups in $SU(2)$*, Trans. Amer. Math. Soc. 326 (1991), 795–828.

[5] C. Herald, *Flat connections, the Alexander invariant, and Casson's invariant*, Comm. Anal. Geom. 5 (1997), 93–120.

[6] P. Braam, S. Donaldson, *Floer's work on instanton homology, knots and surgery*, in: The Floer Memorial Volume, Progr. Math. 133 (1995).

[7] A. Floer, *Instanton homology, surgery, and knots*, in: Geometry of low-dimensional manifolds I, LMS Lecture Notes 150 (1990).

[8] P. Kronheimer, T. Mrowka, *Khovanov homology is an unknot-detector*, Publ. Math. IHÉS 113 (2011).
[9] C. Scaduto, *Instantons and odd Khovanov homology*, J. Topol. 8 (2015).
[10] R. Fintushel, R. Stern, *Instanton homology of Seifert fibred homology three spheres*, Proc. London Math. Soc. 61 (1990), 109–137.
[11] A. Daemi, *Chern–Simons functional and the homology cobordism group*, Duke Math. J. 169 (2020).
[12] Y. Nozaki, K. Sato, M. Taniguchi, *Filtered instanton Floer homology and the homology cobordism group*, J. Eur. Math. Soc. (to appear); arXiv:1905.04001.
[13] A. Daemi, C. Scaduto, *Chern–Simons functional, singular instantons, and the four-dimensional clasp number*, JEMS 26 (2024).
[14] M. Hedden, C. Herald, P. Kirk, *The pillowcase and perturbations of traceless representations of knot groups*, Geom. Topol. 18 (2014).
[15] P. Seidel, *A long exact sequence for symplectic Floer cohomology*, Topology 42 (2003).
[16] J. Hanselman, J. Rasmussen, L. Watson, *Bordered Floer homology for manifolds with torus boundary via immersed curves*, J. Amer. Math. Soc. 37 (2024).